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# 14

# ON ISLAMOPHOBES AND HOLOCAUST DENIERS

## Making Sense of Violence, in Myanmar and Elsewhere

Matt Schissler

The theme for the Australian National University (ANU) 2015 Myanmar Update Conference was "Making Sense of Conflict". The weeks leading up to the conference, held in the first week of June, added to the theme's poignancy and urgency; at least 25,000 Muslims were fleeing persecution and poverty by making the dangerous trip from Rakhine State across the Bay of Bengal (UNHCR 2015). My paper at the conference presented findings from research into the ways people in Myanmar talk about this violence and, in particular, how those Buddhists who direct a sense of threat and antagonism towards Muslims explain and justify it. I had spent the preceding six months managing a "listening project", born from my belief that to make sense of conflict we must listen carefully to the way it